

Football clubs, fans and the imagined community

By Syed Faraz Sabzwari

Introduction

The aim of my research resolves around the broad question of what constructs identities and communities of football club fans in a society. I am interested in understanding the signs and symbols used in context with the sport, football, in order to create a certain sense of an imagined community. Furthermore, I will be analyzing the fan community of the Liverpool football club through the socio cultural aspect which bring about the question of authenticity in fandom. Fan communities desire to distinguish themselves from the “other” “normal” fans. This concept of the perceived authenticity revolves around certain in-group and out-group behavior. I will use my literature to analyze what affects the identity, based on the perceived authenticity, of fans who form communities which have a certain intimate connection with the football club.

Literature review

The concept of studying fans through communities instead of studying them individually is highly contested. However, Avital Margalit, in *“You’ll Never Walk Alone”: On Property, Community, and Football Fans*, argues how the fan is characterized through certain elements of the community such as “participation in a shared way of life, identification with the group and mutual recognition” (Margalit, 2009). The participation of the fan is not limited to the stadium. Many fans still watch football matches in a group setting at their homes instead of going to the stadiums. This participation continues, even after football matches. “It is a continuum of the collective experience” (Margalit, 2009). These fan communities have their own culture, practices and rituals. They even share a collective trauma (Margalit, 2009). Media has contributed a great deal of

communication between the fan communities through social media and fan's internet forums (Margalit, 2009).

Another indicator of the identity of these football fans is through the loyalty associated with the football clubs. A former Manchester United player, Eric Cantona, says "You can change your wife, your politics, your religion, but never, never can you change your favorite football team."

This quote shows an element of passion associated between the relationship of the fans and the football club itself. This loyalty establishes a sense of belonging for the fans and explains how the fans identify themselves. "Fandom means having no real exit" (Margalit, 2009). The identity of a genuine/true fan is associated with this "no exit" perspective where a loyal fan can not switch a football club. Switching a football club is frowned upon and associated with deserting. "In this sense, though not a primordial human grouping, the community of fans and the club do somewhat resemble the family or the state" (Margalit, 2009). This also puts the fans at a disadvantage at times. Since there is no threat of exit, the owners of the football club at times do not pay much attention to these fans and the concerns of these fans may be ignored (Margalit, 2009). Fans are an important part of the football industry and they voice their opinions, about the success of the club and the football players, through gatherings in pubs or social media groups and blogs. Media then plays an active part in allowing the fans to channel their voice and modes of communication. Fans also associate identity through common interests within the fan communities such as interests in the ownership of the football club and the interest in the continuity of their fan community. While the owner of the football club manages the economic activities of the club, the fan communities act as the social owners of the football club. "The fans would be the social or moral owners with an effective formal voice regarding matters most pertinent to their community" (Margalit, 2009). This social ownership allows the football club itself to be a social institution. This social institution

demands for an active role and involvement of these fans. The football club then represents as a social property of these fan communities and remains essential for the continuity of these communities (Margalit, 2009).

With the globalization of the football industry through media, viewers can watch football matches globally without the need to be present in the stadiums. Globalization of the football industry provides these fans the opportunity of involvement through the comfort of their homes which brings about affordability and has increased the number of global overseas fans (Margalit, 2009).

There is a strong relation between the modern sport, media industries and the process of globalization (Nash, 2019). The consequence of this globalization and investment by media industries is that some football clubs become global brands, mainly European football clubs, deliberately exported for consumption to create worldwide fan-bases, with obvious important consequences for fandom (Nash, 2019). Because of this globalization through media industries, football clubs are now more pro active in the market. Football clubs are endorsed by brands and multi national organizations. An example of this is how the football club, Manchester United has a three-year joint Asian marketing deal with Pepsi (Nash, 2019). Similarly, other football clubs sell their merchandise across many countries. A consequence of this is the rise in global overseas fans. An example of this globalization can be observed of how an entire fanbase of the Liverpool football club exists in Scandinavia because of an “accidental” television coverage of English football in Scandinavia (Nash, 2019). That so called “accident” is now central to the profit maximization of English football clubs.

This process of globalization by the football industries affected the local fan base. An example of this is how the Liverpool football club focused a lot more on overseas fans in order to expand globally, mainly Scandinavian fans, which lead to the exclusion of the local fans (Nash, 2019).

This led to issues between the relationship of the local and the global fan base. Issues involved the local fans treating the global fans with hostility upon their visit to any of the matches. Another issue which came about was that the local Liverpool football club fans did not recognize the global fans as “genuine”.

However, a different take on this perspective, according to Rex Nash in *Globalised Football Fandom: Scandinavian Liverpool FC Supporters*, is the attempt by global overseas fans to eliminate differences between the local fans. “Instead of hostility, Scandinavian fans actually found a strong communal ethos with local fans, who treated them as simply another type of supporter. The Danish official noted that ‘when the fans [on tour parties] go into a bar with a LFC shirt on and [the locals] hear you are from another country, they start chatting to you. Many times, I have been offered a beer with them’” (Nash, 2019). This global fandom included the spread of loyalty along with the transmission of the history associated with the Merseyside club, Liverpool, was a result of the globalization of football fandom which reinforced culture through media. An example of this spread of global fandom was through fan magazines or “Fanzines” (Nash, 2019).

Media played a vital role in this globalized fandom, from publishing magazines to television broadcasts all over the world. The football matches, on live broadcast, were portrayed as a spectacle with an atmosphere that included the cheering of fans, singing, chanting and dancing for the support of their football club. This spectacle allowed the spread of globalized fans who could then associate and identify with the culture of the football club (Nash, 2019). This spectacle which was broadcasted on live television also transmitted the history and culture of football clubs, such as Liverpool, through oral traditions such as songs and chants. One such chant associated with the identity of the club is titled “You will never walk alone”.

Football clubs across England had many hostilities between them which meant that there were hostilities between fan communities of these different clubs. For example, Liverpool fans collectively chanted “F*** Man United” and “Stand up if you hate Man United” to show their hostility towards Manchester United football club (Nash, 2019). These rivalries and hostilities between different fan communities was a way of interaction between the fans and an active participation in the English game (Nash, 2019). According to Nash in *Globalized Football Fandom: Scandinavian Liverpool FC Supporters*, many Scandinavian Liverpool football club fan communities could be seen aligning themselves and associating themselves with the masculine traditions such as social interactions, alcohol and hostility, to engage with the traditions and practices of the genuine local fan. This particular pursuit of the genuine fan was instigated by the Finnish fanzine using words such as “real fans” (Nash, 2019).

I will use Grace Davie’s argument in *'You'll Never Walk Alone': The Anfield Pilgrimage* to talk about the Liverpool football club in order to analyze the identity of Liverpool fans. I will analyze the effects on identity of the fans through one particular event, the Hillsborough disaster, in order to understand how particular historic events shape up the identity of the fans and how a football stadium (Anfield stadium of the Liverpool football club) can become a sacred place for the fans where they perform their “pilgrimage”.

The Liverpool football club had to play an away match (away matches are not played on Anfield) on the Hillsborough stadium against the Nottingham Forest team. The Hillsborough stadium was one of the best stadiums in Britain and nobody expected it to collapse on the people in the stadium. This is exactly what happened. “That afternoon 94 people - most of them young and all of them Liverpool supporters - died, watched not only by a capacity crowd but by a television audience numbered in millions” (Davie, 1993). This disaster happened during the match and was

broadcasted globally on sports and news channels. The fans reaction to this disaster is key in understanding the identity of a football fan. What followed the Hillsborough disaster was series of events associated with communal grief. Grace Davie, in *'You'll Never Walk Alone': The Anfield Pilgrimage*, talks about how the people of Liverpool came together and “turned many of its citizens into pilgrims” (Davie, 1993). This disaster brought together the people of Liverpool in a spontaneous way in order to express their solidarity and emotions for the people who had died. The people gathered (pilgrims) at Anfield to perform various rituals of mourning and expressed their emotions towards the lives lost. What was remarkable was the unity of these people and how they organized them selves. These Liverpool people gathered together, in huge numbers, at Anfield, the day after the tragedy (Davie, 1993). This showed how the people found comfort in grieving together. The movie based on the Liverpool football club “Make us dream” talks about the Hillsborough disaster which resulted in the people of Liverpool uniting as fans to participate in the grief. The people gathered and prayed communally in churches and at Anfield. Anfield became a very sacred place and people came there for seven days to mourn and pray for the people who lost their lives. The amount of people that came at Anfield can be best described as “the endless stream of mourners who came to the ground” (Davie, 1993). More and more people arrived every day and there were queues of people waiting outside the Anfield stadium, even before the gates were opened. The Anfield stadium of Liverpool football club became the place of mourning. This mourning constituted of a lot of gestures. One such gesture was commemorating the lost lives by bringing flowers. The Anfield stadium was full of these flowers brought by the people who came to pray and mourn. This public expression of grief reinforced the social solidarity of the community (Davie, 1993). According to Grace Davie, many people could not attend family funerals. They, however, needed a place to grief and the Anfield stadium became that place. This

gathering of people became very significant for the history of the Liverpool football club. This gathering brought the people together in the form of communal grieving which created a family with a shared sense of belonging, purpose and sentiments. “The family, moreover, shared one sentiment more than any other; the insistence that in Liverpool 'you will never walk alone’” (Davie, 1993). This chant became an essential part in the identity of the Liverpool football club and the identity of the fans who associated themselves with Liverpool through the Hillsborough incident. This chant also became a theme which was recited at memorials, funerals and even sermons. The lyrics of the chant are:

“When you walk through a storm

Hold your head up high

And don't be afraid of the dark.

At the end of the storm there's a golden sky

And the sweet silver song of a lark.

Walk on through the wind,

Walk on through the rain,

Tho' your dreams be tossed and blown;

Walk on, walk on with hope in your heart

And you'll never walk alone,

You'll never walk alone”

This chant comes from the song by Richard Rodgers and Oscar Hammerstein from their musical titled *Carousel* (Davie, 1993). This song is still chanted today by the Liverpool fans in the Anfield stadium to bring back their sense of belonging and pledge their loyalty to the Liverpool football club. According to Grace Davie, the practices observed by Liverpool fans can draw a comparison between football and religion. Davie mentions how religion has certain rituals and sacred places that bring together people. Similarly, as observed in the aftermath of the Hillsborough disaster, the Liverpool fans observed the Anfield stadium as a sacred place and performed certain rituals such as the pilgrimage to Anfield.

I will further reiterate on the relationship of football, as a sport, and the institutions of society in order to understand the construction of fan identities. I will use *Sport and religion: culture, history and ideology* by Andrew Parker and Nick J. Watson to understand how religion, education and media, as social institutions, affect sports which consequences in the identities of fans. “sport does not exist in a social vacuum. Rather, it evolves and develops in accordance with a variety of cultural and historical practices whilst at the same time embedding itself further into the fabric of everyday life” (Parker and Watson 2013). Sports is shaped by society and its cultural practices. These developments in sport took place in the 19th century when sport was being looked at as more than a leisure activity and were transformed into “structured and codified games” (Parker and Watson 2013) through the English schooling system. The religious institutions, the second half of the twentieth century recognized the importance of sport as an agent of socialization and created sports ministries (Parker and Watson 2013). Sport has become a “cultural spectacle” (Parker and Watson 2013) because of the advancement in technology which allows a wider audience. Sports has an intimate relationship with media in the sense that the media is responsible for the broadcasting of sport through many television networks and media platforms. Such media

coverage and world wide broadcasting of sports leads to consumerism. The Liverpool football club's fans in Pakistan, for example, may be a result of this consumerism through globalization and commercialization.

Since my focus lies on understanding the identity of Liverpool football fans, I will use Philipp Budka & Domenico Jacono's *Football fan communities and identity construction: Past and present of "Ultras Rapid" as sociocultural phenomenon* in order to understand the formation of a specific fan identity known as the Ultra Rapid. The Ultra Rapid is a specific fan community of the football club SK Rapid Wien. Using this literature, I will try to analyze how fan identities, individual and collective, are shaped by fan culture. This literature also attempts to explain part of my research question which aims to understand the concept of the perceived authenticity. This specific fan community, Ultra Rapid, tries to distinguish themselves from "normal" fans as the "Ultra" fans (Budka and Jacono 2013). Fan communities like the Ultra Rapids or the Liverpool fan community are created through social relations that exist outside the workplace or private space. These social relations are constructed through space and time in order to create, what Benedict Anderson refers to as, the imagined community (Budka and Jacono 2013). According to the concept of Benedict Anderson, the community is only imagined and exists within the minds of the members. The social relation in fan communities is based on similar interests, similar locality and similar social structure (Budka and Jacono 2013).

Football, like religion, comprises of rituals, culture and symbolic communication (Budka and Jacono 2013). Philipp Budka & Domenico Jacono also argue that for some fans their football club is as important or sacred to them as their religion.

With globalization and technological advances, football teams rely on media to become a highly marketable product (Kerr and Emery 2011). Fans of the English teams now exist globally because of internet and satellite television. Even though teams like the Liverpool football club are based in England, its fans exist globally. “For many sport fans, a foreign team often becomes ‘an ‘overseas sweetheart,’ far away but close to the heart’” (Kerr and Emery 2011). A fan of a football team doesn’t necessarily have to be present in the country of the football team or be physically present at the stadium during the matches. Because of globalization, fans involvement is more psychological instead of physical. This psychological connection between football teams and the fans is essential in the construction of the fan identity (Kerr and Emery 2011). Fan’s initially identity, as a fan of a particular team, is created through agents of socialization such as family members or peer groups. However, media has recently been observed as an important agent of this socialization process. The use of media, as an agent of socialization, explains how fans identify to particular teams whose hometown is far away. An example of this can be the fans of the Liverpool football club based in Pakistan. “The Liverpool FC has more than 200 international supporter branches” (Kerr and Emery 2011). With the growth of the media industries and the process of globalization, many teams, such as Liverpool, have become household names. These global fans are referred as “satellite supporters” by Kerr and Emery. “Satellite supporters present a valuable opportunity for marketers to tap into a lucrative fan base and enhance their own team brands” (Kerr and Emery 2011).

Football not only reflects the society and its culture but also becomes a part of how certain groups symbolize their culture and identities through imitation, fandom and sometimes violence (Merkel 1999). Given that football fandom is predominantly male, it is important to study masculine forms of pride and the values that are deeply associated with the football culture. In Germany, football

matches have become a place for construction, reconstruction and celebration of identities and culture (Merkel 1999). While analyzing the relationship between football and identities, it is important to look upon the intersection between gender identities and fan identities. Even men whose fan practices do not conform to hegemonic masculinities attempt to do “real man” practices which often results in hooliganism (Merkel 1999).

I will also be looking into the Hillsborough and Heysel tragedies which are very important events which may help understand the identity of the Liverpool fan. I will use the work of Hughson and Spaaij titled *'You are always on our mind: The Hillsborough tragedy as cultural trauma*. This literature will help me understand the communal grief and the history of a Liverpool fan.

In order to tackle the question of authentic fandom, I will be using the work of Leon Davis in *Football fandom and authenticity: a critical discussion of historical and contemporary perspectives*. This particular work focuses on the question of authentic fandom and involves an argument based on a Marxist perspective. According to this literature, fandom is very much correlated to social class. This literature makes an argument that football spectatorship was originally part of the working class culture and that, gradually, this spectatorship changed from a working class audience to a middle class audience. This reading correlates globalization to the rise of the global fan but argues that the category of the modern fan may not lie under the definition of authenticity.

In order to build upon a particular definition of authentic fandom, I will be using the work of Richard Giulianotti in *SUPPORTERS, FOLLOWERS, FANS, AND FLANEURS*. This literature sheds light on four particular categories of fandom. These categories help understand and distinguish between the different types of fandom. According to Richard Giulianotti, the *supporter* is the closest fan category to remain authentic.

The Hillsborough disaster – (A historic event viewed as a symbol)

The historical event which I will be looking into would be the Hillsborough disaster of 1989. Significant events like these exposes the identity of the fans much more clearly, according to me. On the 15th of April 1989, the Liverpool team played against Nottingham Forest at the Hillsborough stadium during which the stadium collapsed, and many people lost their lives (Hughson and Spaaij 2011). Many people from the Liverpool fan community lost their lives and so public tragedies like these consequences in public grief. Emotions are shared together with entire communities. The Hillsborough tragedy brings forth the concept of cultural trauma and a sense of communal grief for the Liverpool fan community. This cultural trauma serves as an “analytical lens” through which we view the Liverpool fan culture (Hughson and Spaaij 2011). This Hillsborough tragedy brought back the pre-existing notion of hooliganism which had been a problem in England since the late 1960s (Hughson and Spaaij 2011). The Heysel stadium tragedy, in Brussels, happened just before the Hillsborough tragedy when the Liverpool team played against Juventus. In the Heysel tragedy, the Liverpool fans were blamed for rampaging and forcing their way through the spectators when the one of the walls of the stadium collapsed resulting in the deaths of mainly Juventus fans (Hughson and Spaaij 2011). The aftermath of both these tragedies resulted in a negative picture of Liverpool fans and this fan community and the city of Liverpool were associated with violence and hooliganism (Hughson and Spaaij 2011). This association of hooliganism with a particular fan community must be looked at according to the broader culture of Liverpool which includes poverty and a large proportion of Irish ethnicity. With the Irish migration in the twentieth century, the city of Liverpool suffered economically. The word “hooligan” itself can be traced back to an Irish family named Hoolihan (Hughson and Spaaij 2011). The two tragic incidents mentioned above along with the pretext of Irish migration gave the perfect

opportunity to ascribe the city and fans of Liverpool with hooliganism. The first incident at Heysel started the stereotype of hooliganism ascribed to Liverpool fans and the incident of Hillsborough, a few years later, reaffirmed the stereotype. Some Liverpool supporters never attended another Liverpool match after that incident (Hughson and Spaaij 2011). So, in a way, the two tragedies have become a part of the identity of Liverpool fandom. Many news broadcasters specifically blamed the Liverpool fan community for both these instances which otherized the Liverpool fans from the rest of England.

Although, at an individual level, every fan must have gone through their own process of mourning and grief, but the materiality of cultural trauma lies with the community instead of particular individuals or families. The grief and the suffering of the Liverpool fans had a collective dimension and so the communal grief made the fan community come closer together (Hughson and Spaaij 2011).

The model used by Sztompka talks about the cultural trauma theory which can be used to analyze the communal grief of the Liverpool fans and the outcomes of the Hillsborough and Heysel tragedies on the identities of Liverpool fans (Hughson and Spaaij 2011). According to John Hughson and Ramón Spaaij, in *'You are always on our mind': The Hillsborough tragedy as cultural trauma*, the tragic events brought the fan community of Liverpool closer together. Thus, collective cultural trauma made room for a positive cultural change. One of my respondents, who has spent time living in the city of Liverpool, talked about how the Liverpool fan community is very close with each other and that Liverpool fans can be very emotional. Perhaps, as Sztompka suggests, the historical events did have a certain impact on their identity as fans. One of the effects of this can be the importance of the Anfield stadium which is the home stadium in the Liverpool

city. This stadium became a place for communal grieving for all Liverpool fans after the tragedies of Hillsborough and Heysel.

Bibliography

Margalit, Avital. 2008. ""You'll Never Walk Alone": On Property, Community, And Football Fans". *Theoretical Inquiries In Law* 10 (1). doi:10.2202/1565-3404.1214.

Nash, Rex. (2019). Globalised Football Fandom: Scandinavian Liverpool FC Supporters.

Davie, Grace. 1993. "'You'll Never Walk Alone'". *Pilgrimage In Popular Culture*, 201-219. doi:10.1007/978-1-349-12637-8_9.

Parker, Andrew, and Nick J. Watson. 2013. "Sport And Religion: Culture, History And Ideology". *Movement & Sport Sciences - Science & Motricité*, no. 86: 71-79. doi:10.1051/sm/2013063.

Budka, Philipp, and Domenico Jacono. 2013. "Football Fan Communities And Identity Construction: Past And Present Of "Ultras Rapid" As Sociocultural Phenomenon". *Paper At "Kick It! The Anthropology Of European Football" Conference*.

Kerr, Anthony K., and Paul R. Emery. 2011. "Foreign Fandom And The Liverpool FC: A Cyber-Mediated Romance". *Soccer & Society* 12 (6): 880-896. doi:10.1080/14660970.2011.609686

Merkel, Udo. 1999. "Football Identity And Youth Culture In Germany". *Football Cultures And Identities*, 52-63. doi:10.1057/9780230378896_5.

Hughson, John, and Ramón Spaaij. 2011. "'You Are Always On Our Mind': The Hillsborough Tragedy As Cultural Trauma". *Acta Sociologica* 54 (3): 283-295. doi:10.1177/0001699311412623.